Chapter 3: The Game That Changed Everything

"Hey guys, now that it's just us, how about we play one of those party games we used to play when we were kids? No offence, Cameron, but your party… it's a bit boring," Maria asked the group.

"I take no offence at all. I'm just as bored as you are," I replied. "What game were you thinking?"

"No clue. Any ideas?" Maria asked the group again. I could see everyone trying to think of some games that we could play. I didn't have any, since I was never one to be invited to any parties.

"Ooh, I have one – what about seven minutes in heaven?" I heard Noah say.

Maria almost instantly shot his idea down by saying, "Of course you'd choose that one, you sex-crazed maniac. Well, seeing as I'm the only girl here, and I'm *happily* in a relationship, I don't think that would be a good idea."

"Yeah man, I'm *right here*." Braeden piped up, in agreement with Maria's protest.

"A. I'm not crazy, and B. I'm not a maniac. It's not my fault if I like sex. Well, then what about truth or dare?" Noah said. Everyone seemed to be okay with that idea.

"Um, how do you play that one?" I asked.

"Oh yeah, Cameron's kind of a hobbit," Noah mocked me. "Well, the idea is that we sit in a circle and one by one ask someone else in the group whether they want to tell a truth or do a dare. If they choose truth, you can ask them a question, and they have to answer it honestly. If they choose dare, you get to make them do something. Then, they get to pick the next person. Get the idea?"

"Seems straightforward enough, I guess. What are the rules?"

"Rules?" he continued to mock me, laughing. "There are no rules! Ask anything, dare anything! I'll start. Maria: truth or dare?" he asked.

"I'll start with truth, I don't even want to *know* what you'd dare me to do." Maria responded.

"Hmm…" Noah paused, thinking of what to ask. "Oh, I know. Besides Braeden, who in the room would you be in a relationship with?" he asked her. I was instantly uncomfortable with what he asked, probably because of my complete lack of a social life, let alone a romantic life, but everyone else seemed to be fine with it.

"Oh, definitely Cameron." She answered, almost instantly. "I know he's gay, but for some reason, I'd love to know who he is on a deeper level, and what he's like in the bedroom." She said, confidently. I instantly started blushing. I mean, how could I not? I was not expecting her to answer that at all.

"Woah. I was NOT expecting that." Noah said in response.

"Oh, I know what you were hoping for, Mr. Hockey Captain. Not going to happen. Ever. In your wildest dreams." She shot him down, before turning to me and asking, "See how it works?"

"I guess so, sure." I responded.

"Great – prove it. Cameron: truth or dare." She asks me.

"Um, truth—no, dare. Dare." I chose.

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“Ooh, interesting…” she said. She leaned over to Braeden, whispering something in his ear. I saw him nod slightly before she excitedly asked me “I dare you to come over here and let me kiss you.”
“Do I have a choice?” I asked.
“No. You made your choice already. Now come here and let me kiss you!” she ordered me. I crawled over to her, and she grabbed my head and kissed me right on my lips. “I’ve always wanted to do that,” she said, nearly jumping with joy. “Your lips are so soft.”
“Um, thanks, I guess. So are yours.” I slowly responded to her compliment, embarrassed. I mean, the kiss was fine, and it felt good to have someone want to kiss me, but I’m as far from straight as possible. I would have much preferred it to be Noah who dared me to kiss him. “So now it’s my turn? I pick someone now?”
“So, you do get it!” she mocked me.

“I guess I’ll choose Noah. Truth or dare?” I asked him.
“I’m going to play it safe and go with truth,” he said.
“Okay… um… I’m genuinely curious. Who of us would you most like to be in a relationship with?”
“Interesting question. Though I would like to know what it’s like to be with Maria—” he started saying, while she once again yelled “Never going to happen!” from across the room, “— I’m also kind of into you, Cameron. I’m going to have to agree with Maria on that one. I’m kind of jealous she got you before I did,” he answered.
“You know you have to answer honestly, right?”
“Yeah – I am being honest. I genuinely want to know what it would be like to date you.” I saw a look of utter shock on everyone’s faces as I looked around the room, unaware that I had a similar look on my face. “What? Did I say something wrong? Why’s everyone looking at me like that?” Everyone started laughing, except for me. I felt paralyzed after I heard what he said, part of me still thinking he was joking, despite his supposed honesty. Was this a signal? For some reason, I didn’t think so, still assuming he was straight. In retrospect, I can see now that it was an obvious signal, and I should have paid attention to it. The night was only starting, and it was about to get much better, even though neither of us knew it.

Noah chose Mitchell next, to everyone’s surprise, and we kept going. I wasn’t chosen much, and even when I was, I couldn’t focus. Probably because everyone could see how embarrassed I was after Maria’s turn, and after what Noah had said.

The game had been going on for a while now, and honestly, I’d gotten bored of it pretty much as soon as it started. But since everyone came, I decided to *try* to play along, hoping for the best. It was my turn - I chose Noah again, and asked “Truth or Dare?” Noah pondered for a moment and replied “Ah, might as well - dare.” *Was this the moment? Should I try something?* I thought as I tried to figure out what I was going to dare him to do. “Um…” I hesitated. “I dare you to…” The

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words stuck in my throat like I couldn't continue, despite how much I wanted to. I took a big gulp and continued. "I dare you to kiss someone in the room".

I didn't think he'd choose me, even after what he had said - I mean he's a jock, so he's got to be straight, right? There's *literally* no way he'd ever choose me. Noah looked around the room before, to my surprise, his eyes locked on me. *Wait a second. Is this really happening?* I thought before I heard Noah's voice. "Cam," he said in a low and daunting tone. He knew I didn't like being called Cam, but I could feel my heart beat through my chest. I felt like I couldn't breathe, almost as if I could only take shallow breaths. Maybe I did like it – but only from him? *Did I upset him? What if I upset him? This wouldn't ruin our friendship, right?* I thought. I could only wait to hear what he was going to say. The next thing I heard made all my concerns just fade away, as if they'd never existed in the first place. "Get over here." The second the words came out of his mouth, I was nearly shaking, and speechless.

Oh. My. God. I thought instantly. *This isn't happening*. *Maybe it's just a joke. Yeah, a joke. A cruel joke. Am I really about to have my first kiss with a guy with the person I fantasized about spending the rest of my life with so many times?* I nervously and slowly crawled across the room and sat next to him. "You know I don't like that–" I started to complain, but he interrupted.
"I know – that's why I did it," he said, giving me the cutest little smirk, the same one he had on his face when he did something mischievous. He paused, almost like he was reconsidering what he said, before he grabbed my arms. He said, "Just shut up and kiss me, you nerd," before he kissed me so passionately, I didn't even know what was going on. It only lasted for a few seconds, but to me, it lasted forever.

"Well nerd, how was it?" he asked, laughing, with that grin on his face, almost to say that he liked it as much as I did.
"That was…" I said, shakily, pausing to catch my breath. "That was amazing," I replied. That was an understatement: in reality, it felt like I was on a cloud of happiness I'd never known before, but I could never let him know that. He leaned in close to my ear, so I could feel his warm breath on my skin and whispered, "if you liked it so much, maybe we should do it again sometime."
I whispered back to him, "I think I'd like that," running my fingers through his smooth, silky blond hair, which he seemed to enjoy as much as I did.
He leaned in closer, took my hand, rubbed it, and whispered, "and maybe a bit… *more*." He emphasized the last word, almost to tell me that he knew of my feelings towards him and that he really did mean what he said. It was almost like… he felt the same way about me. For some reason, that signal I did catch, *loud and clear*, despite how quiet we were.

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It stuck in the air around us. It was all I could think about – nothing else mattered. Nothing else existed. Just the two of us. But there was no way that he actually felt the same way I did. *Right?* I thought to myself, still doubting what I heard. *Right*. My feelings were like a pot of water boiling over: I felt like I couldn't control them. It took everything for me to not just tackle him to the floor and passionately make out with him, rip his clothes off, and just have sex with him right now in front of everyone. Was I the sex-crazed maniac Maria thought he was? Not really, but for some reason, tonight, and especially around him, I was. Somehow, I avoided it, as much as I didn't want to. Noah chose Maria next, but I can't remember what she chose and what he asked. I was still thinking about our kiss.

A knock at the door broke my wandering mind. I opened it, and it was the delivery person bringing the food I ordered. It was time for dinner, so we all gathered around my square dining room table. Noah sat right next to me like he promised he would while we were outside. Across from us were Maria and Braeden – of course they sat together, while Mitchell was sitting alone. While we ate, I couldn't stop thinking about what had just happened between us – it was a fantasy of mine for quite some time to be in a relationship with Noah – but I didn't think he'd ever feel the same way. All the hottest girls at school were all over him. I mean, how could they not be? He's the hottest specimen of human I've ever seen. I'd never be able to compete with that. Specifically, the whole "girl" thing, but I guess the "hottest" thing too. Every now and again, I felt him gingerly rubbing my thigh with his hand under the table, and I occasionally caught him staring at me or giving me the odd suggestive wink. When he stared at me, I could only stare right back into his perfect blue eyes – the eyes that I'd always loved.

After we finished eating, we all gathered in the living room. Maria asked us all, "Hey guys, I didn't get to take my last turn during the game. Can I do it now?" I looked around the room to the sight of everyone doing the same, while thinking about who she was going to ask, and what she could possibly want to know or force someone to do. Almost in unison, we all said something allowing her to take her turn. "Cameron – truth or dare?" she asked me.
"Dare, I guess," I responded, the boredom obvious in my voice.
"I dare you and Noah to go into that hall closet and play seven minutes in heaven together." She jumped up and down, clapping her hands together a few times.
What the actual hell? Did she notice my reaction to his kiss? Did she hear our whispers?
"What?" I sharply asked her with a look of surprise on my face.
"You heard what I said – you up for it or not?" she said, laughing.
I looked at Noah, surprised, and I saw him looking back at me with that same grin as before.
"I'm down if you are. I did want to play seven minutes in heaven anyways," he said to me. It was almost like he could see right through my face into my mind, and he could see the desire I held to be with him.
"I guess… I'm down," I said, slowly.

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“Then get to it, boys!” Maria ordered as she ran over to the hall closet and opened the door. She motioned for us to enter.
Noah and I stepped into the closet, and Maria closed the door on us. From inside, I heard her voice faintly say, “Seven minutes – starting… now!”
“So… um, what do we do now?” I asked Noah.
“How about we take things from where we left off, and see what happens?”
“Sure – let’s do that,” I said, as Noah jumped on top of me and started kissing me with just as much passion as he did before.

Somehow, the secrecy of it all made it feel better. I began caressing the side of his head as we continued to make out. I felt his hand on mine, and I felt him moving it from his face, down to his neck, and to his chest. Between the kisses, I barely got out “can I—,” before I heard him say, almost as if he was reading my mind and like he was out of breath, “do it – please – go under my shirt,” before returning his mouth to mine. I moved my hand down to the bottom of his shirt, feeling his hand leave mine before attaching itself to my face. I slowly went under his shirt and crept my hand back up to his chest. As I moved across his body, I felt his toned abs, which I’d always admired from a distance and have always wanted to feel for myself. I found myself distracted by them for a few seconds, before moving my hand further up, back to his chest, where I continued the same rubbing motion I did from over his shirt. The strange part: I couldn’t feel any chest hair. He was clean-shaven, which was unexpected. I liked it even more.

I heard him quietly moan, “mmm” as I rubbed him. Shortly after I started rubbing, I felt his body move away from mine. “What are you doing?” I ask him, quickly and concerned.
“Nothing – just giving you *easier access*,” he said seductively as he took off his shirt, allowing me to stare at his abs and chest, which I could barely see with the dim lighting in the closet.
“Now you,” he said.
“Really? You want to see me shirtless?” I asked him, scared of what he might say if I were to take off my shirt.
“I do.”
“Um, okay, I guess… Just don’t make fun of me,” I said as I complied somewhat reluctantly and slowly took my shirt off for him.
“Aw, you’re cute under all that nerdy stuff,” he said jokingly, but also seemingly genuinely, while also laughing.
“What do you mean *cute*? You’re better looking than I am,” I said.
“You’re beautiful in your own way – no matter what anyone else says.”
“And you’re okay with it? Okay with… *me*?” I asked him, still scared of his reaction.
“Why wouldn’t I be?”
“I – I don’t know, I just didn’t expect—” I started saying as Noah pulled himself closer to me and continued kissing me to shut me up and put my mind at ease. It worked to shut me up, but

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my mind was still racing. I put my hand back on him, but this time I felt his hand work its way down to my chest and stomach.
"See? Beautiful," he said, between the episodes of kissing, while he rubbed me the same way I rubbed him, which *did* calm my mind.

"Two minutes left!" I heard Maria say from outside the closet. I could only think about two things: that we were in the closet for five minutes straight, kissing, and that Noah accepted me for who I was – and what my body looked like – when he was the hottest guy I'd ever seen.
"Hey – mind if I try something?" He asked me while I was mid-thought.
"Try what?" I asked him, trying to get as much information from him as possible before giving him permission.
"You'll see – I think you'll like it," he answered seducing me.
It was obvious that he wasn't going to give up any information, so I decided to just go along with it. It was him, after all. "I guess, sure, why not? I've already got you half-naked. What else could go—" I started saying, as I felt him grabbing my hand and putting it over his pants. I quickly jerked my hand away from him and said, "Woah, what are you doing?"
"I'm just… testing the waters a bit – did you not like it?" he asked.
"Well, I'm not saying I didn't like it—"
"Then why'd you pull away?"
"I – I just wasn't ready for that – for any of this. It's all… overwhelming."
"Well, are you ready now?"
"I think so," I said slowly as I put my hand back on his pants, rubbing his groin from the outside. I could feel his dick through his pants. He was already hard – *Is he enjoying this? Am I enjoying this?* Of course I was, I'd wanted this for so long, but why was he enjoying it? We're just friends, and he's as far away from gay as I am away from straight. I felt him move his hand down from my face, through my chest and abdomen, down to my pants. "Ooh, someone's excited," I heard him whisper into my ear as he started to rub me as I was rubbing him, before returning his soft lips to mine and continuing to kiss me.

"And that's time!" Maria yelled, before whipping the door to the closet open. We both ignored her words and her actions. We didn't stop. We *couldn't* stop. To us, the door was still closed, and we were still alone. "Oh, wow," I heard her say, laughing, which snapped both of us into the cruel reality. Noah and I finally stopped and looked at her, our hands still glued to each other's groins. I saw see she had a look of shock on her face, as did the others. "Am I interrupting something?" she asked, still laughing.
"Well, we – you –" I tried to put some string of words together to resemble some sort of a sentence, but I couldn't. Filled with both the lust of what had happened, and the embarrassment of being caught by everyone, I couldn't seem to think, let alone construct a sentence.
"Well, it's your fault Maria – you dared us to do this. Live with it, girl!" Noah snapped at her, laughing back, and giving her the same sinister grin he gave me. She quickly turned around,

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almost as if she was angry at us, and walked back to Braeden, who was still on the couch, and still in shock by the sight of us.

Noah kissed me lightly one more time before caressing my face one more time, putting his shirt back on and joining the rest of the group. I sat there in the closet for about another minute, trying to decipher what just happened, and trying to convince myself that it was real. *I want him so much,* I thought to myself, *if only…* before putting my shirt on and joining everyone else, my mind still wanting more time with him in that closet.

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